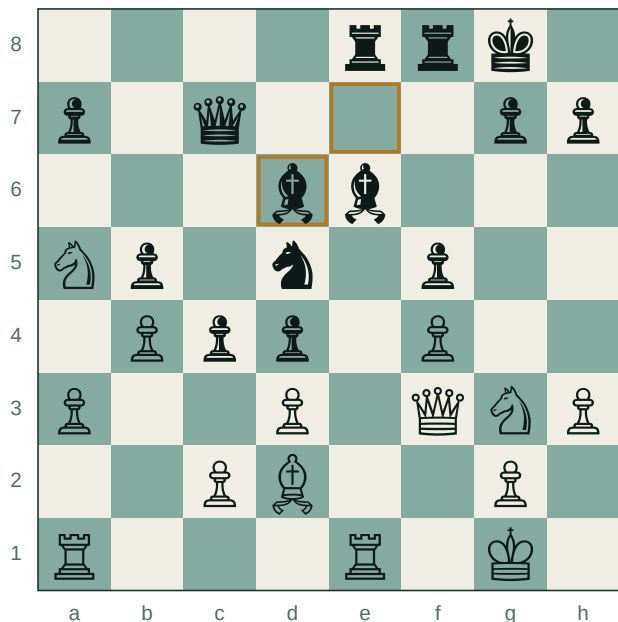


Capture the defender: White, move 21

Capture the defender

White to move



Previous move: 20...Bd6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

21. Rxe6 Rxe6 22. Qxd5

21.Rxe6 The rook captures the bishop on e6. From e6 it attacks rook on e8 and bishop on d6. Recorded reply: **21...Rxe6**.

22.Qxd5 The queen captures the knight on d5. From d5 it attacks rook on e6 and bishop on d6.

At the end, nominal material is White 30 / Black 29 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +1:** the balance goes from +0 to +1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g8. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.